

THE ASTEROID BELT

Between the orbits of Mars and Jupiter lies a large region of rocky debris left over from the formation of our Solar System 4.6 billion years ago. Put together, these rocks, called asteroids, would weigh only one-thousandth of our planet's mass. Astronomers have discovered half a million of these asteroids, and spacecraft have taken close-up pictures of a dozen of them.

DATA FILE



DISTANCE FROM THE SUN: 270–620 million km (167–385 million miles)



YEAR OF DISCOVERY: 1801, when Giuseppe Piazzi discovered Ceres



SMALLEST ASTEROID: 145779 (1998 CC), 0.3 km (0.2 miles) in diameter



LARGEST ASTEROID: Ceres, 946 km (590 miles) in diameter